The decision to centrally procure uniforms for students in state-run schools, taken by Shinde's schools minister (and partyman) Deepak Kesarkar, also stands annulled. Sources say the process was marred by glitches and complaints of poor quality.

A senior bureaucrat says Fadnavis, after taking over as CM in December 2024, has moved quickly to impose his control and authority over the state administration, posting hand-picked officials in crucial positions. In particular, the CM's secretariat is said to be closely monitoring the functioning of departments controlled by ministers of the two Mahayuti allies, the Shinde Shiv Sena and NCP. 'Monitoring', in fact, is an understatement. Earlier in February, industries minister Uday Samant (Shinde Sena) had even written to the principal secretary (industries) and CEO of the Maharashtra Industries Development Corporation (MIDC) about policy decisions being taken without keeping him in the loop.

OTHER FLASHPOINTS

- **CM's office vetting appointments of personal secretaries, PAs and OSDs of ministers of Mahayuti allies**
- **Shinde not in State Disaster Management Committee initially, but Ajit Pawar is. Finds a place later**
- **CMO opens a medical aid cell for indigent patients; Shinde starts separate cell controlled by close aide Mangesh Chiwate**
- **CM Fadnavis creates a war room to monitor flagship projects. Shinde and Pawar start copycat project monitoring centres**
- **Security downgrade for ministers/netas purportedly targets Sena MLAs, who feel upstaged by NCP/BJP counterparts**

The three parties in the Mahayuti are also ranged against each other over the contentious appointment of 'guardian ministers' for districts. Fadnavis has been forced to keep on hold the appointment of the NCP's Aditi Tatkare and the BJP's Girish Mahajan as the guardian ministers of Raigad and Nashik respectively, after the Shinde Sena took umbrage to it.

Meanwhile, in what is seen as a direct challenge to Shinde on his home ground Thane, the BJP's forest minister Ganesh Naik has begun organising '*janata darbars*' here. Naik, a former Shiv Sainik, has hinted that the BJP can contest and win the municipal elections in Thane on its own, sans an alliance with the Sena, a sentiment that senior BJP leaders have also been echoing for the Mumbai civic polls.

A senior NCP leader feels Shinde's initial reluctance to back the BJP's claim for the chief minister's post may have affected his position in the Mahayuti. In contrast, the NCP's deputy CM Ajit Pawar immediately supported Fadnavis, and is seen as being in a much more comfortable position. The NCP leader says the cash-strapped state government's moves to scrutinise the beneficiaries of the flagship 'Ladki Bahin Yojana,' in which over 23 million indigent women were given monthly doles of Rs 1,500 under the Shinde regime, and the rethink on schemes like the free pilgrimage for senior citizens, has eroded the latter's political capital. Power relations between "us and the BJP have changed", admits a Shiv Sena leader, "our problem now is that we have no party apparatus to speak of. We are now more of a group of MLAs who have coalesced around Shinde and the power that he wields," he says.

NEW CM FADNAVIS HAS ROLLED BACK MANY DECISIONS TAKEN IN SHINDE'S TENURE, AND ALSO ORDERED A PROBE INTO SOME OF THEM

Amidst all this, Shinde's move to accept an award from Sharad Pawar, head of the Opposition NCP(SP) faction, has created ripples in both the Mahayuti and the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA). Pawar Sr is seen as the glue holding together the MVA, which includes the politically disparate Congress and the Sena (UBT). NCP(SP) spokesperson Anish Gawande, though, brushes aside the incident, saying that Pawar has "always maintained that it is the culture of Maharashtra to treat political opponents as ideological opponents and not as enemies".

Analyst Abhay Deshpande says that in 2022, Fadnavis too had accepted the deputy CM's post despite being the chief minister from 2014-19. "The difference is that Fadnavis had to accept his party's diktat, and Shinde had to swallow this bitter pill as the chief of his party to ensure its future," he adds. He describes Shinde's aggression as an attempt at underlining his identity and that of his party in the coalition, to prevent it from being subsumed by the BJP. He attributes Ajit's nimbleness in supporting the BJP and Fadnavis to his old political DNA, which derives from that of the Congress. The Sena's culture lacks that flexibility, claims Deshpande. The Mahayuti has also been unable to counter the narrative about the dissonance in the alliance, he points out.

The Shinde Sena is also trying to shore up its ranks with the hush-hush 'Project Tiger', trying to wean away leaders from MVA parties, especially the rival Shiv Sena (UBT). A major catch has been former three-term Sena (UBT) legislator Rajan Salvi. His move to join Shinde instead of the BJP, as was being speculated earlier, will also serve as a counter-balance to the influence of industries minister Uday Samant and his brother Kiran aka Bhaiyya (who defeated Salvi in the assembly election from Rajapur in Ratnagiri district). MVA leaders have claimed in the past